The then Canadian prime minister, Pierre Elliot Trudeau, was fighting many battles on several political and economic fronts. His government was pushing for a charter of rights in Canada's constitution, policy experts were facing the heat over rising inflation, and the inflation provided enough ammunition to political parties like the Conservatives and the New Democrats to target Trudeau's government. Above all the Canadian government was unnerved by revelations that two former Canadian envoys had been working as moles for the Soviet Union. Trudeau strongly denied these charges, but the scandal did not die down.

Back in India, the government's conscious decision to deploy the IB, the domestic spy agency, for espionage operations abroad, was an extraordinary step that had rattled the R&AW which guards its territorial jurisdiction jealously. In Krishna's candid opinion, the IB proved to be far superior in the Canadian theatre than the R&AW. Under suitable diplomatic cover, they operated from 10, Springfield Road in Ottawa, and managed to cultivate and recruit sources close to Sikh separatist leaders including the Babbar Khalsa's Talvin-der Singh Parmar, Surjan Singh Gill and Manjit Singh Kohli.

Talvinder had played a key role in the crash of Air India Boeing 747 'Kanishka' on 23 June 1985, in which three hundred and twenty -nine people were killed. After the crash, Indian authorities played the usual blame game, accusing each other either of lack of intelligence or failure to act on available forewarnings.

A US embassy report said that the possibility of an attack on Air India had been widely known in the weeks before the bombing. They were right. The terror modules that executed the attack